Internal linking strategy template

A template to plan and control the links between your pages: page priorities, an anchor text register, a hub-and-spoke map, a link plan, a quarterly audit, decisions on orphan pages, and results and next steps. Fill it in by hand or in any PDF editor.

Website (URL) _____ Date prepared _____

Owner _____ Next audit due _____

How to use this template

1. **Record your baseline** (part 1): a crawler, your XML sitemap, the Links report in Search Console.
2. **Pick your priority pages** (part 2) and give each a priority from 1 to 3.
3. **Assign their anchors** in the register (part 3).
4. **Draw the hub-and-spoke map** (part 4): each hub and its spoke pages.
5. **Write the link plan** (part 5), starting with priority 1 pages.
6. **Every quarter**, run the audit (part 6) and decide on orphan pages (part 7).
7. **Measure the effect** (part 8) in Search Console.

The rules in brief

- The hub links to every spoke, and every spoke links back to the hub.
- New content: a link to the hub and to 2–4 pages in the same cluster; the hub links to it on the day it goes live.
- Priority 1 pages get the most incoming internal links.
- Important pages sit no more than 3 clicks from the homepage.
- Anchor text is descriptive and concise; one anchor = one target page.
- Link to the canonical, final URL with no redirects; use an <a href> element, no nofollow.

1. Baseline and following quarters

Record the values before your first changes, then every quarter using the same method. Quick check of up to 25 pages: the free SEO audit at ai-seo-company.pl.

METRIC	SOURCE	START	Q2	Q3	Q4
Date measured	–				
URLs in the XML sitemap	sitemap.xml				
URLs found by following links (200, indexable)	Crawler				
Orphan pages (sitemap only)	Crawler and sitemap				
Internal links to 4xx/5xx pages	Crawler, free SEO audit				
Internal links through redirects	Crawler (audit: chains only)				
Important pages deeper than 3 clicks	Crawler (crawl depth)				
Priority 1 pages among the most linked pages	Links report in Search Console				

2. Page priorities

Priority 1: service pages, categories and content that bring in leads. Priority 2: pages that support sales. Priority 3: everything else. Target: how many incoming links the page should have, and from where.

PAGE URL	TYPE (SERVICE, CATEGORY, HUB, ARTICLE)	CLUSTER	PRIORITY	INCOMING LINKS TODAY	TARGET	CLICK DEPTH
Example: /bathroom-renovation	*Service, hub*	*Bathroom renovation*	*1*	*4*	*Links from 5 cluster pages and the homepage*	*1*

3. Anchor text register

Descriptive, reasonably concise anchor text, no keyword stuffing. The same anchor text never points to two different pages. For image links, the alt attribute is the anchor.

TARGET PAGE	PRIMARY ANCHOR	ALLOWED VARIANTS	DON'T USE (BELONGS TO ANOTHER PAGE)
/bathroom-renovation	*bathroom renovation in Warsaw*	*bathroom renovation; how we run a bathroom renovation*	*"pricing" (belongs to /pricing)*

4. Hub-and-spoke map

One cluster = one primary keyword for the hub. Tick the links that already exist. An empty box = a link to add in part 5.

HUB AND SPOKE PAGES (URL)	HUB → SPOKE	SPOKE → HUB	LINKS TO 2–4 CLUSTER PAGES (WHICH)
Example. Hub: /bathroom-renovation · spoke: /blog/bathroom-renovation-cost	*yes*	*yes*	*tiles guide, Mokotów case study*
Cluster 1. Hub:			**Primary keyword:**
1.	☐	☐	
2.	☐	☐	
3.	☐	☐	
4.	☐	☐	
Cluster 2. Hub:			**Primary keyword:**
1.	☐	☐	
2.	☐	☐	
3.	☐	☐	
4.	☐	☐	

5. Link plan

Start with links to priority 1 pages. Placement: B = body copy, M = menu, BC = breadcrumbs, F = footer, R = “related” block. A link in the body copy carries the most context.

NO.	SOURCE PAGE	TARGET PAGE	ANCHOR TEXT	PLACEMENT	LIVE	DATE
–	*/blog/apartment-bathroom-renovation*	*/bathroom-renovation*	*bathroom renovation in Warsaw*	*B*	*yes*	*12 Jan*
1					☐	
2					☐	
3					☐	
4					☐	
5					☐	
6					☐	
7					☐	
8					☐	
9					☐	
10					☐	
11					☐	
12					☐	

6. Quarterly internal linking audit

The same criteria every quarter and after every major change (migration, new menu, URL changes). In each quarter's column, write OK or the number of issues. Move issues to part 5 or 7.

NO.	CRITERION AND HOW TO CHECK	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4
1	**Every important page has a link from at least one other page** Crawler: sitemap URLs that no link points to.				
2	**Important pages within 3 clicks of the homepage** Crawler: crawl depth report.				
3	**Zero internal links to 4xx and 5xx pages** Crawler or the free SEO audit. Fix the link at the source.				
4	**Links point to the final URL, with no redirects on the way** Crawler; the free audit flags redirect chains.				
5	**Links point to canonical URLs, not duplicates** Compare the linked URL with the target page's canonical tag.				
6	**Priority 1 pages are among the most linked pages** Links report in Search Console (a sample, max. 1,000 rows) against part 2.				
7	**Descriptive anchor text; one anchor points to one page** Anchor export from the crawler against the register in part 3.				
8	**Links are <a href> elements present in the HTML, no onclick or links** Page source, or the rendered HTML in URL Inspection.				
9	**No important pages with a single incoming link, no pages overloaded with links** Crawler: incoming and outgoing links per page.				
10	**Links to important pages without rel="nofollow"** Crawler: filter internal links with nofollow.				

7. Orphan pages and decisions

Link it: an important page, or one with impressions (positions 4–20). Merge: several weak pages on one topic (301). Remove: no traffic, links or value (410, or 301 to the parent page). Noindex: a page people need but search results don't. Update the sitemap after each decision.

URL	HOW WE KNOW	DECISION	LINK FROM / 301 TO	OWNER, DUE DATE
		☐ link it ☐ merge (301) ☐ remove (410) ☐ noindex		
		☐ link it ☐ merge (301) ☐ remove (410) ☐ noindex		
		☐ link it ☐ merge (301) ☐ remove (410) ☐ noindex		
		☐ link it ☐ merge (301) ☐ remove (410) ☐ noindex		

8. Results and next steps

In Search Console, compare 28 days before the change with 28 days after Google has recrawled the source pages. Incoming links: the Links report or your crawler.

TARGET PAGE	DATE LINKS WENT LIVE	INCOMING LINKS BEFORE / AFTER	CLICKS, 28 DAYS BEFORE / AFTER	AVG. POSITION BEFORE / AFTER
		/	/	/
		/	/	/
		/	/	/
		/	/	/
		/	/	/
		/	/	/

Review findings and tasks for next quarter

What worked, what didn't, and why. Move tasks with an owner and a due date to part 5 or 7.

FINDING OR TASK	OWNER	DUE DATE